Both the BRS and the BJP have criticised the survey—which was conducted door-to-door over 50 days—alleging data discrepancies. BRS working president K.T. Rama Rao says BC numbers have actually declined by five per cent compared to the 2014 survey, while the Other Caste (OC) figures have dropped from 21 per cent to 15 per cent. But Congress minister N. Uttam Kumar Reddy defends the latest numbers, claiming the BRS regime's survey had no legal sanctity and the BC population has in fact risen from 51 per cent to 56 per cent (including BC Muslims) over the decade.

Implementing quotas based on the survey poses significant legal challenges. The Supreme Court's 50 per cent cap on reservations is a major hurdle, requiring any law passed by state legislatures to be included in Schedule 9 of the Constitution through a constitutional amendment. The unresolved issue of four per cent Muslim reservation under the BC (E) category too is pending before the apex court. Nevertheless, Revanth Reddy has promised to provide 42 per cent reservation for BCs in party nominations for local body elections, for now, and to enhance reservations in education and employment.

The survey's success will hinge on Revanth's ability to navigate this complex social, political and legal landscape. As Harathi Vageeshan, a political science professor at NALSAR University, Hyderabad, says, "Using this data for mere electoral purposes will not help the Congress much, but if it uses it for substantive human development endeavours, then this will go a long way for the party." The true test of the caste survey lies in its ability to translate data into meaningful action, ensuring that the Congress's stated commitment to equitable growth addresses the diverse needs of caste and community cohorts. ■

JAMMU & KASHMIR

THE TURF WAR

By Kaleem Geelani

In Kashmir's Budgam, the hoisting of the tricolour on Republic Day by District Development Council (DDC) chairperson Nazir Ahmad Khan was marked by a conspicuous absence—none of the district's four MLAs attended the event. This sparked an angry reaction from Khan, who urged locals to question their representatives—all belonging to the ruling National Conference (NC). "Despite invitations, they didn't give a hoot," Khan, now an Independent but formerly with the Peoples Democratic Party, remarked in his address. Within the NC, too, tensions simmer. In Bandipora, the party's DDC chairperson, Abdul Gani Bhat, was left to cut a sorry figure as both NC legislators skipped the function.

This was in stark contrast with what was seen in Srinagar, Baramulla and Anantnag, where most local MLAs were in attendance as NC ministers presided over the functions, thus highlighting a deepening rift between the traditional legislators and the newly empowered DDC members. Its seeds were sown with the imposition of Governor's Rule in 2018 and the J&K Reorganisation Act, 2019, that bifurcated the old state into Union territories. This was followed by an amendment to the J&K Panchayati Raj Act, 1989, in October 2020, which introduced DDCs to oversee development at the district level in the absence of an elected assembly since 2018. The first election for DDCs in December 2020 filled 14 seats in each of the 20 districts, establishing these Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) as key political and financial hubs. However, with the formation of the Omar Abdullah government in October 2024, a turf war has erupted.

The 90 elected MLAs find themselves sidelined, as the scrapping of the Constituency Development Fund (CDF) under the 2019 Act has left them without resources for local projects. Meanwhile, DDCs have flourished, each with an annual purse of Rs 10 crore. "Earlier, we [PRIs] enjoyed no powers or fi-



A NEW REALITY Omar Abdullah at a press briefing, Jan. 2

AFP